

The Information Daily Briefing — 2026-08-13

Coverage window: last 24 hours (Aug 12, 2026 issues) • Source: The Information

2026-08-13

The Information Daily Briefing — 2026-08-13

Prepared from The Information's newsletters received over the last 24 hours (The Information AM, The Briefing, The Electric, The Information Finance — Aug 12, 2026 editions). Times referenced are US ET/PT as published.

Top Stories — What / Why / When / Which / How

1. Google's Gemini app hits 1 billion monthly users

- **What:** Google's Gemini consumer app reached 1 billion monthly active users, which CEO Sundar Pichai called the fastest-growing product in company history.
- **Why:** It signals Google is closing the consumer-AI gap on OpenAI's ChatGPT (which hit ~1 billion weekly users and 2M+ businesses on July 31) and is monetising distribution advantages across Search, Android and Apple.
- **When:** Announced Tuesday, Aug 11 (Pichai on X); reported in the Aug 12 AM briefing.
- **Which:** Alphabet/Google, OpenAI/ChatGPT, Apple (~100M Gemini users flow through Apple Intelligence/Siri, which Google's model powers).
- **How:** Distribution muscle — 63% of users engage Gemini directly; the app added ~50M MAUs in under a month (from 950M at last earnings).
- **Link:** <https://www.theinformation.com/briefings/googles-gemini-app-hits-1-billion-monthly-users>

2. CoreWeave's revenue doubles — but so does the cash burn

- **What:** Neocloud CoreWeave reported Q2 revenue up 112% to \$2.575B, but free-cash-flow burn also roughly doubled to \$5.7B; adjusted EBITDA doubled to \$1.5B.
- **Why:** It crystallises the core neocloud question — whether hyper-growth AI infrastructure can ever convert to real profit given crushing capex and rising debt costs. Capex jumped to \$6.4B (from \$2.45B a year ago); D&A more than doubled to \$1.39B; interest costs rose 140% to \$640M.
- **When:** Q2 results reported Tuesday, Aug 11; analysed in the Aug 12 “The Briefing.”
- **Which:** CoreWeave (CRWV); by extension other neoclouds and their GPU suppliers.
- **How:** Debt-financed data-center build-out; The Information flags “adjusted EBITDA” as a “nonsensical” metric here because it strips out the very interest and depreciation

that define the model. Stock still rose 13–14% after hours as investors prioritised growth.

- **Link:** <https://www.theinformation.com/briefings/coreweaves-revenue-doubles-cash-burn>

3. Lithium-metal / silicon battery startups find their first real market: drones

- **What:** Next-gen battery makers (silicon-anode and lithium-metal) are winning commercial traction powering military drones for the Pentagon and Ukraine. Amprius says its silicon batteries will power drones from ~half of the 19 manufacturers competing in the Pentagon's \$1.1B "Drone Dominance" program.
- **Why:** After years of struggling to crack mass-market EVs (the chemistries degrade under sustained high power), single-use kamikaze drones are the ideal use case — range, speed and one-way missions where degradation doesn't matter.
- **When:** Aug 12 edition of The Electric; references Amprius' Q2 call last week and the Pentagon competition "later this month."
- **Which:** Amprius Technologies (AMPX), Factorial Energy, South Korea's BEILab, Redwire (RDW, \$40M Amprius order for its Stalker Block 30), nanotube maker OCSiAl; adviser context from About:Energy and Tesla adviser Jeff Dahn.
- **How:** Carbon nanotubes ("turn garbage into gold") extend cell life and speed charging. Pentagon plans 60,000 drones by end-September and up to 250,000 more by 2028; Amprius guides ~\$140M 2026 revenue, 25% gross margin, first small EBITDA profit, and US manufacturing next year (likely a Pentagon requirement).
- **Link:** <https://www.theinformation.com/electric>

4. Wall Street-style hedging comes to AI "tokens"

- **What:** Compute Exchange is launching "token forwards" — privately negotiated contracts letting enterprises lock in AI token prices for up to six months — plus a "standardized token unit" benchmark. Separately, CME Group set an October launch for two exchange-traded GPU futures contracts (pending regulatory review).
- **Why:** Token/inference spot prices have become highly volatile (OpenRouter prices that were stable for days now move hourly). After "tokenmaxxing," firms like Uber and ServiceNow blew through annual AI budgets in months; predictable pricing is now a survival tool. Deloitte sees inference at ~two-thirds of AI workloads by end-2026 (up from one-third in 2023).
- **When:** Reported Aug 12 in The Information Finance; CME contracts due October 2026.
- **Which:** Compute Exchange (4% fee), CME Group (CME), WEKA (AI memory infra); inference providers running open-weight models from DeepSeek, Moonshot AI and Alibaba — cheaper than frontier Anthropic/OpenAI models.
- **How:** Buyers post model/pricing/throughput specs; six signed-up inference providers bid; matched buyers commit to a token volume. Risks flagged: thin liquidity and counterparty risk.
- **Link:** <https://www.theinformation.com/finance>

5. Crypto's fastest-growing venues lobby for a US path as the Clarity Act stalls

- **What:** With the Senate postponing its vote on the crypto Clarity Act (now “all but dead for the moment”), fast-growing offshore venue Hyperliquid (perpetual futures) and lending platform Morpho are lobbying US regulators to operate under existing law.
- **Why:** Perpetual futures and DeFi lending were largely uncovered by the stalled bill; firms want to protect/expand US access without waiting for new legislation.
- **When:** Reported Aug 12 (The Information Finance / dedicated article).
- **Which:** Hyperliquid, Morpho; US agencies (CFTC/SEC) as the regulatory counterparties.
- **How:** Direct outreach via policy and legal representatives seeking favorable interpretation of current rules.
- **Link:** <https://www.theinformation.com/articles/hyperliquid-looks-path-u-s-markets-perpetual-futures>

6. Money keeps flowing: Kalshi, Anton Levy's Layer Global, Sacks' Craft, Pragmatik

- **What:** Prediction market Kalshi's annualised revenue doubled to >\$4B in July (from ~\$2B two months earlier) as it seeks a ~\$40B valuation; Anton Levy's Layer Global closed a first \$1.1B on its debut fund; David Sacks' Craft Ventures targets \$1B for its first post-White House fund; and ex-Alibaba Qwen lead Junyang Lin unveiled Pragmatik Labs (~\$2B valuation, backed by HongShan, Gaorong, Tencent).
- **Why:** Capital is concentrating in AI and AI-adjacent platforms even in a tough fundraising market (PitchBook: slowest first-time-fund period since 2016; a16z, Thrive and Founders Fund raised nearly half of all H1 venture dollars).
- **When:** All in the Aug 12 issues.
- **Which:** Kalshi, Layer Global/General Atlantic lineage, Craft Ventures, Pragmatik Labs, Tencent, HongShan, Gaorong.
- **How:** Kalshi's growth is marketing-fueled (\$300M June opex) and it keeps raising (third round in eight months), hinting it isn't yet clearly profitable.
- **Links:** <https://www.theinformation.com/briefings/exclusive-anton-levys-layer-global-raises-1-1-billion-first-close> · <https://www.theinformation.com/briefings/former-alibaba-researcher-announces-new-startup-digital-physical-ai-agents>

7. Also moving: OpenAI attrition, Manus spin-out, SpaceXAI × Cursor “Grok Bot,” OnlyFans fintech

- **What:** Brad Lightcap (OpenAI special projects, ex-COO) is departing; Manus will return as an independent company as its Meta deal unwinds (Chinese-government ordered); SpaceXAI and Cursor launched agent product “Grok Bot” (beta) as SpaceX's \$60B Cursor acquisition nears close; OnlyFans' new investor Architect Capital plans creator financial products.
- **Why:** Continued churn at OpenAI's senior ranks (following Fidji Simo and safety chief Johannes Heidecke); China-US tech deal reversals; agents moving from demo to workplace tools; fintech-for-creators as a new monetisation vector.
- **When:** All Aug 12.

- **Which:** OpenAI, Meta, Manus, SpaceX/SpaceXAI, Cursor, OnlyFans/Architect Capital (16% stake at ~\$3B).
 - **How:** Manus users must back up post-Dec-29 data by Aug 23 (two-day outage Aug 23–24); Grok Bot agents sign into work accounts to send email, manage CRM, negotiate with vendors.
 - **Links:** <https://www.theinformation.com/briefings/openai-special-projects-lead-former-coo-brad-lightcap-depart> · <https://www.theinformation.com/briefings/spacexai-announces-ai-agents-product-grok-bot> · <https://www.theinformation.com/articles/onlyfans-new-investor-reveals-financials-ipo-ambitions-rare-interview>
-

Overall Market Summary

Trend. The dominant thread is the *industrialisation and financialisation of AI infrastructure*. Compute and now tokens are becoming tradable, hedgeable commodities (Compute Exchange token forwards, CME GPU futures), while the physical build-out (CoreWeave, neoclouds, the Nvidia-backed \$500B Wall Street alliance referenced earlier in the week) keeps scaling. Consumer AI distribution is consolidating around two mega-platforms — Google Gemini (1B MAU) and OpenAI ChatGPT (1B WAU) — with everyone else fighting for the layer beneath.

Development. Two frontiers matured this cycle: (1) *inference economics* — cost predictability is now a board-level concern, and open-weight models (DeepSeek, Moonshot, Alibaba/Qwen) are cheap and “increasingly competitive,” pressuring frontier-model pricing; and (2) *AI at the physical edge* — next-gen batteries and drones show AI-era hardware finding real revenue in defense, an area with durable, multi-year government demand.

Sentiment. Constructively skeptical. Investors are rewarding growth over profitability (CoreWeave up ~13–14% despite \$5.7B burn; capital still flooding into Kalshi, Layer Global, Pragmatik) but The Information’s own commentary is pointedly cautious on metrics (calling CoreWeave’s adjusted EBITDA “nonsensical”) and on repeat capital raises (Kalshi). Risk appetite is high, but the quality of earnings is under growing scrutiny.

Key Questions & Risks Being Asked

- **Can neoclouds ever generate real free cash flow?** CoreWeave’s \$5.7B burn and 140% jump in interest expense raise the question of when — or whether — capex normalises and debt service becomes sustainable. Reliance on adjusted EBITDA is a red flag.
- **Is frontier-model pricing power eroding?** If enterprises hedge token costs and shift to cheap open-weight models, margins for Anthropic/OpenAI-tier providers could compress. Counterparty and liquidity risk in nascent token-forward markets is unproven.

- **How durable is the drone/defense battery demand?** Amprius' outlook hinges on Pentagon programs and a required shift to US manufacturing; concentration risk (single-use military drones as the main market) is high.
 - **Regulatory overhang in crypto.** With the Clarity Act stalled, offshore venues (Hyperliquid, Morpho) face an uncertain US path; outcomes depend on regulator interpretation rather than statute.
 - **Governance/attrition at OpenAI.** Continued senior departures (Lightcap, Simo, Heidecke) prompt questions about execution and stability at the sector's bellwether.
 - **Valuation vs. profitability.** Kalshi's need to raise a third time in eight months despite a soaring revenue run-rate underscores the gap between top-line momentum and cash generation.
-

Potential Investment Implications (companies directly mentioned)

For information only — not investment advice. I am not a financial adviser; verify data and do your own diligence before any decision.

- **Alphabet / Google (GOOGL):** Gemini's 1B MAU validates distribution-led AI monetisation and the Apple relationship. Positive read on consumer-AI share; watch cost of serving and Search cannibalisation.
- **Apple (AAPL):** ~100M Gemini users route through Apple Intelligence/Siri — reinforces Apple's model-supplier dependence on Google; a strategic and optics risk more than a revenue one.
- **CoreWeave (CRWV):** High-beta proxy for AI capex. Revenue momentum is real, but \$5.7B burn, rising leverage and reliance on adjusted EBITDA argue for caution on quality of earnings.
- **Nvidia (NVDA):** Indirect beneficiary of neocloud/data-center build-outs and GPU futures markets; demand narrative intact, but concentrated in debt-funded customers like CoreWeave.
- **Amprius Technologies (AMPX):** Clearest single-name beneficiary of the defense-drone battery theme (~\$140M 2026 rev guide, first EBITDA profit, Pentagon exposure). Small-cap, concentration and manufacturing-ramp risk.
- **Redwire (RDW):** \$40M Amprius battery order for its Stalker Block 30 ties it to the drone-procurement wave.
- **Intel (INTC):** Referenced raising ~\$15–20B in an upsized share sale to fund AI/expansion — dilution now for capacity later; execution-dependent.
- **C3.ai (AI):** USDA tapped C3 AI to trim its Salesforce footprint — a modest but notable enterprise/government win.
- **Salesforce (CRM):** Same USDA item is a mild competitive/negative signal (footprint being trimmed at a large federal account).
- **CME Group (CME):** New GPU futures (October) position it to capture AI-infrastructure hedging volumes — an incremental new product line.

- **Alibaba (BABA):** Qwen open-weight models feature prominently in cheaper inference; ex-Qwen talent (Pragmatik) and China AI momentum are strategically relevant.
 - **Amazon / AWS (AMZN):** “AWS tells engineers to cut CPU waste amid crunch” (popular item) hints at capacity pressure in incumbent cloud amid AI demand.
 - **Private/pre-IPO to watch:** OpenAI, Anthropic (IPO chatter), Kalshi (~\$40B target), Manus, SpaceX/Cursor, OnlyFans/Architect, Layer Global, Craft Ventures, Pragmatik — relevant for private-market and eventual-listing exposure.
-

Sources

All items sourced from The Information newsletters delivered Aug 12, 2026 (US time) to the subscriber inbox:

- The Information AM — “Google’s Gemini App Hits 1 Billion Monthly Users” (Aug 12): <https://www.theinformation.com/briefings/googles-gemini-app-hits-1-billion-monthly-users>
- The Briefing — “CoreWeave’s Red Ink” (Aug 12): <https://www.theinformation.com/briefings/coreweaves-revenue-doubles-cash-burn>
- The Electric — “After Years Looking For a Market, Lithium Metal Battery Startups Find One in Ukraine” (Aug 12): <https://www.theinformation.com/electric>
- The Information Finance — “How One Startup Is Bringing Wall Street-Style Contracts for AI Tokens” (Aug 12): <https://www.theinformation.com/finance>
- “Hyperliquid Looks for Path to U.S. Markets for Its Perpetual Futures” (Aug 12): <https://www.theinformation.com/articles/hyperliquid-looks-path-u-s-markets-perpetual-futures>
- “Exclusive: Anton Levy’s Layer Global Raises \$1.1 Billion in First Close” (Aug 12): <https://www.theinformation.com/briefings/exclusive-anton-levys-layer-global-raises-1-1-billion-first-close>
- “Former Alibaba Researcher Announces New Startup on Digital and Physical AI Agents” (Aug 12): <https://www.theinformation.com/briefings/former-alibaba-researcher-announces-new-startup-digital-physical-ai-agents>
- “OpenAI Special Projects Lead, Former COO Brad Lightcap To Depart” (Aug 12): <https://www.theinformation.com/briefings/openai-special-projects-lead-former-coo-brad-lightcap-depart>
- “SpaceXAI Announces AI Agents Product ‘Grok Bot’” (Aug 12): <https://www.theinformation.com/briefings/spacexai-announces-ai-agents-product-grok-bot>
- “OnlyFans’ New Investor Reveals Financials, IPO Ambitions in Rare Interview” (Aug 12): <https://www.theinformation.com/articles/onlyfans-new-investor-reveals-financials-ipo-ambitions-rare-interview>

Note: a few feature newsletters (The Electric, The Information Finance) do not expose a per-article slug in the email; links point to the relevant section. Deep-link slugs are used where the email provided them.